200 constitutes a "clear embargo" on further gubernatorial resistance once the legislature reaffirms a bill.

Role of the Governor

In the Constituent Assembly debates of 1949, B.R. Ambedkar had stated: "The Governor under the Constitution has no functions which he can discharge by himself; no functions at all." That intent came under stress almost immediately after, from independent India's first election in 1952. In Madras, Governor Sri Prakasa invited Congress's C. Rajagopalachari to form the government despite the United Democratic Front winning more seats, setting a precedent of favouring the Centre's ruling party. President's Rule became another weapon in the hands of governors—the Centre imposed it more than 100 times before 1994 till the Supreme Court reined in this misuse through the landmark *S.R. Bommai vs Union of India* verdict in 1994. It ruled that assembly floors—not governors—must test a government's majority, and that Article 356 is subject to judicial review. The impact was stark: average annual impositions of President's Rule dropped from six to 1.5 after the judgment.



"When a governor deliberately sits on bills passed by an elected assembly, it's democratic sabotage"

ABHISHEK MANU SINGHVI, *Jurist*

The BJP's ascendance to power at the Centre in 2014 marked a turning point in the governor-state relationship, particularly in Opposition-ruled states. From Kerala to Punjab and Tamil Nadu to West Bengal, governors appointed by the BJP-led central government have been engaged in increasingly bitter confrontations with elected state governments. "The Governor's office has been weaponised into a *supari* agency for the Centre—an instrument not of guidance, but of harassment and disruption," says jurist and four-time parliamentarian Abhishek Manu Singhvi.

Though, constitutionally, the governors are envisaged as constitutional heads who would act on ministerial advice except in rare circumstances outlined in the founding document, some governors have explicitly articulated a more assertive stance. West Bengal Governor C.V. Ananda Bose, for instance, has declared: "The governor should be active. The concept of passive governor has gone." Adopting a literal interpretation of constitutional provisions, governors in many states are asserting powers not conventionally exercised. Former Kerala Governor Arif Mohammad Khan, for

GOVERNORS VS CHIEF MINISTERS

Across India, governors are at odds with state governments, fuelling constitutional showdowns, ideological clashes and political manoeuvring. Raj Bhavans are now flashpoints where questions of federalism, executive overreach and institutional integrity are being contested



ANI

TAMIL NADU

The confrontation between Tamil Nadu governor **R.N. Ravi** and Chief Minister **M.K. Stalin** has been one of the most intense Centre-state face-offs. From withholding assent to key bills—including legislation curbing his powers as university chancellor—to staging walkouts from the assembly, Ravi has repeatedly defied constitutional convention. In April 2025, the Supreme Court ruled his inaction on pending bills "erroneous and illegal", emphasising that governors cannot indefinitely stall legislation. The conflict has also assumed other dimensions. Ravi's suggestion to rename the state as "Tamizhagam" was seen as an affront to Tamil identity. His omission of social justice themes and key leaders in official speeches bred mistrust. What began as procedural friction has evolved into a symbolic struggle between federal authority and state assertion.